STUDY SKILLS FOR CERTIFICATE LEVEL (MPU1223)

GROUP REPORT: STRESS MANAGEMENT

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INTRODUCTION TO STRESS

Stress represents a physiological and psychological reaction to external pressures or demands, referred to as stressors. It can manifest as either acute (short-term) or chronic (long-term) and has varying impacts on individuals. Stressors can be classified into three main categories: environmental, social, and internal stressors.

Some examples of these stressors can be related to work, financial stability, relationship & family issues, and health concerns (Wegbom et al., 2023). As mentioned in the book written in the year 1967, titled "The Journal of the Royal College of General Practitioners", the author mentioned that "the greater the pressure, the more likely it is that the recipient, whether a person or a load-bearing beam, will succumb." which basically means that when the external stimulus becomes overwhelming, the internal system can break down.

Another approach to understanding stress is from a response-based viewpoint, which considers stress as a reaction to harmful or aversive stimuli (Koval, 2016). There are three stages that describe the progression of the physiological response to stress. In the initial stage, the body becomes activated, leading to an alarm reaction in response to stress. The second stage, known as resistance, involves autonomic activity preparing the body to cope with the stressor. Finally, in the stage of exhaustion, if the stress persists and the body lacks the capacity to respond adequately, it may result in damage, and the system may collapse (Koval, 2016).

INTRODUCTION TO STRESS MANAGEMENT

Stress Management is all about taking charge of your own thoughts, emotions, schedule, environment and the way you deal with problems.

Stress management also involves using various techniques and coping strategies to improve the way you react to stressful things in your life and build resilience. But it's also not “one size fits all”, that's why it is important to experiment and find out what is the best option for you.

Why does stress management matter?

If you are having high levels of stress, there's a high chance you’re putting your entire well being at risk. Stress can cause havoc on your emotional equilibrium, as well as your overall physical and mental health. It narrows your ability to think clearly, function effectively and enjoy life.

THE TYPES OF STRESS

There are over seven types of stress, but for short, this report will focus on just seven. Stress is an unavoidable part of life, affecting us in many ways and it comes from many different sources that's going to be mentioned later on in this report. Recognizing the different types of stress can help us manage it more effectively, supporting both our mental and physical well-being.

- **Acute Stress**

  A common form of stress, arises from challenging or threatening situations like exams or arguments. While short-term, it can provide energy and alertness, but frequent episodes can lead to health issues.

- **Chronic Stress**

  Resulting from persistent issues like financial issues or job stress, can lead to severe health consequences like cardiovascular disease, depression, and weakened immune system..

- **Episodic Acute Stress**

  Often experienced by individuals with chaotic lives, can lead to anxiety, irritability, and persistent tension, causing headaches, hypertension, and other stress-related conditions.

- **Emotional Stress**

  Triggered by personal or interpersonal relationships, can lead to sadness, anxiety, and depression, often requiring support from friends, family, or mental health professionals.

- **Physical Stress**

  Resulting from overexertion, injury, illness, or lack of sleep, can cause fatigue, muscle tension, and weakened immune response. Maintaining a balanced lifestyle is crucial.

- **Environmental Stress**

  Influenced by external factors like noise pollution, poor air quality, overcrowding, and extreme weather, can be mitigated by minimizing exposure and creating a comfortable living and working environment.

- **Psychological Stress**

  Triggered by internal pressures, unrealistic expectations, and negative self-talk, can lead to feelings of inadequacy, low self-esteem, and anxiety, requiring effective management strategies.

THE SIGNS OF STRESS

When you're stressed out, the hormones produced by your body in a stressful situation can trigger a variety of physical and emotional responses.

You may feel sick or dizzy, anxious, worried, or nervous, or become tense, angry, short-tempered, or even despairing. While physically, you may react by sweating excessively, experiencing muscle aches, chest pains, blurred eyesight, or itchy skin.

But many symptoms of stress can be less immediately noticeable. That's because the most dangerous thing about stress is how easily it can creep up on you. In fact, many of us simply get used to it. After a while, feeling constantly stressed can start to feel familiar, even normal. You don't notice how much it's affecting you, even as it takes a heavy toll on your health and well-being.

THE CAUSES OF STRESS

Stress is a common response to life's challenges as it can last a long time and it will lead to long term health problems. Knowing the main causes of stress can help people find ways to manage it. Some key causes of stress include work pressures, financial issues, relationship problems, health problems, life changes, environmental factors, and personal expectations.

Work and school demands are major sources of stress due to the heavy workloads, strict deadlines, and high expectations which can overwhelm people. Things like job insecurity and fear of unemployment adds to this stress as well. Students face stress from exams, assignments, and social pressures, affecting the well-being of our minds. Difficulty in balancing work or school with personal life is also a common cause of stress.

Also, stress can also be caused by financial worries such as managing the bills, any unpaid debts, and daily expenses. These financial worries can feel overwhelming and can lead to long term health issues, especially with the loss of a job or your income being reduced.

Relationships, both family and social can feel great as they become pillars of support in one's life. On the other hand, they also come with family conflict, caregiving duties, and the hurdles of friendship which can all lead to emotional strain. Furthermore, social expectations and pressure to keep up with others is a big source of stress. In fact, the term "Hikikomori", which translates to "severe social withdrawal", is a form of stress usually caused by the heavy burden of societal pressure. It cannot be denied that these stressors may result in an individual neglecting their social life.

As mentioned previously, dealing with physical or mental health issues adds a lot of stress to an individual. Chronic conditions such as heart disease, diabetes, or any ongoing pain that requires constant management might mean regular doctor visits, daily medications and sometimes adjustments to one's lifestyle. The constant need for monitoring, treatments, and adjustments can be exhausting and financially draining to maintain.

Mental health struggles such as anxiety and depression, further intensify the stress. For caregivers supporting their loved ones with health complexity, the physical and emotional demands can feel extremely overwhelming.

Which leads us to the next point. Another significant source of stress is navigating major life events, including the positive ones such as moving to a new place, getting married, starting a new job, or having children. All of these examples bring new responsibilities and adjustments to life that can feel overwhelming. A negative major change such as the loss of a loved one or changes in relationships can lead to deep and long lasting grief or emotional stress.

Environmental stressors can also add significant strain to an individual's life. Factors like constant noise, pollution, and crowded living spaces can negatively impact health and increase stress levels. Long-term exposure to noise or poor air quality, for example, can wear down an individual's physical health (and also their mental health). Daily frustrations like long commutes and traffic congestion eat into personal time, while living in unsafe or overcrowded neighborhoods can contribute to chronic stress. This type of stress often builds up subconsciously, gradually accumulating until it reaches a breaking point.

Our next point is that high personal expectations can contribute significantly to stress. Individuals who set unrealistic goals or strive for perfection often feel the intense pressure to meet these standards set by themselves. The fear of failure, combined with the constant comparisons to others, especially on social media, can amplify stress and build up feelings of inadequacy or imperfection towards oneself. This pressure gradually accumulates, leading to emotional strain as the gap between expectations and reality widens. How much of an impact this type of stress has often depends on the individual's mindset. Those with a weaker mindset may be more likely to internalize negative comments, further intensifying their stress.

OVERCOMING STRESS

- **Seeking Professional Help**

  If stress becomes too much to handle and affects your daily life, it's a good idea to seek help from a counselor or mental health professional. Therapy can help you learn helpful ways to manage stress. These people can potentially eason your frustration as they have sociological ways to help you. (Example: many schools and universities provide free counseling services for students to talk about their problems and get advice on dealing with stress and anxiety from experts.)

- **Sleep Management**

  Not getting enough sleep can make stress worse. Students need to make sure to get good quality sleep and try to get between 7 to 9 hours every night. Establishing a bedtime routine and staying away from screens before sleep can help you sleep better. (Example: avoiding caffeine and big meals in the evening, as well as reducing screen time an hour before bed, can support improved sleep.)

- **Healthy Eating**

  Eating healthy and getting enough sleep are important for managing stress. A balanced diet is crucial for overall well-being. Consuming foods high in vitamins and minerals can help the body handle stress better. (Example: acids from salmon and walnuts, and antioxidants from blueberries and leafy greens, can boost brain function and lower stress levels.)

- **Time Management**

  Managing stress can be made easier by creating a schedule to organize your time effectively. Students can make a schedule for studying each day or week. This way, they can plan time for schoolwork, relaxation, and hanging out with friends. Having a good schedule can make students feel less stressed and ensure they finish their work on time. (Example: using a planner or digital calendar can help decide which tasks are most important and divide big assignments into smaller parts. This helps students avoid procrastination and stay focused.)

- **Physical Activity**

  Exercising is a good way to lower stress levels. Exercise causes the release of endorphins in the brain. Endorphins are chemicals that help reduce pain and improve mood. (Example: Students can participate in activities such as jogging, swimming, yoga, or taking a short walk to help reduce stress. Physical activity can improve focus and help clear your mind.)

- **Spending Time in Nature**

  Studies have found that being outside, especially in nature, can help lower stress and enhance mental clarity. (Example: when a student is stressed out from exams, they could go for a walk in the park to relax, improve their mood, and reduce tension.)

- **Listening to Music**

  Listening to calm or soothing music can help activate the nervous system to promote relaxation and reduce anxiety. This can lead to lower heart rate, reduced blood pressure, and decreased levels of the stress hormone cortisol. (Example: a student who is nervous before a important test can try listening to soothing classical music, such as pieces by Bach or Chopin, to relax and feel more at ease while studying or taking breaks.)

- **Relaxation and Mindful Techniques**

  Mindfulness meditation and deep breathing can help lower stress levels. These methods help students concentrate on the here and now, relax their minds, and lessen anxiety. (Example: a student can spend 10 minutes every morning doing deep breathing or guided meditation to reduce stress hormone levels (cortisol) and enhance concentration.)

- **Build Your Support System**

  Having conversations with friends, family, or a counselor can really help reduce stress. Having someone to talk to about your feelings can make you feel better and give you support as a student. (Example: Talking to a friend can help a student feeling stressed about exams. The friend can give advice, show understanding, or just listen.)

- **Setting Boundaries**

  A lot of students feel stressed when they take on too many activities, like school, clubs, or hanging out with friends. Knowing when to say "no" is very important for managing stress. (Example: If a student has a lot of work to do, they may say no to joining a new club or taking on a new project. This way, they can avoid having too much to do all at once.)

THE CONSEQUENCES OF STRESS

Stress symptoms may be causing health issues, even though they may be attributed to sickness, such as headaches, sleep issues, and work-related issues. Understanding the symptoms of stress is crucial for us to manage them effectively, as untreated stress can lead to health issues such as high blood pressure, heart disease, stroke, obesity, and diabetes. If you have stress symptoms, taking steps to manage your stress can have many health benefits. Here are some stress management tips for example:

- Get regular physical activity on most days of the week.
- Practice relaxation techniques. Try deep breathing, meditation, yoga, tai chi or massage.
- Spend time with family and friends.
- Set aside time for hobbies. Read a book, listen to music or go for a walk. Schedule time for your passions.
- Write in a journal.
- Get enough sleep.
- Eat a healthy, balanced diet.
- Stay away from tobacco and alcohol use, and use of illegal substances.

So when should you ask for help?

If you're unsure whether stress is the cause, or if you've tried managing it but still experience symptoms, consider visiting your healthcare provider as they can check for other possible causes. You might also think about consulting a counselor or therapist, who can help you identify sources of stress and develop effective coping strategies. If you have any thoughts of self-harm, reach out immediately by calling 911 or a suicide hotline. Additionally, seek emergency assistance right away if you experience chest pain, especially if it's accompanied by shortness of breath, pain in the jaw, back, shoulder, or arm, sweating, dizziness, or nausea. These could be signs of a heart attack, not just stress symptoms.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, stress can affect your physical and mental health a lot more than you think. So, it's quite important to recognise when we do need help. It may be a little difficult to ask for help in the beginning but it’s definitely worth the effort in the long run. And ultimately, managing our stress properly will allow us to have a better life even if it’s slightly.

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